



Vatavyadhi

Learning Objectives

- ⇒ To learn the concept of Vatavyadhi
- ⇒ To learn the Nidana Panchaka of Vatavyadhi mentioned in Ayurveda literatures
- ⇒ To frame out the probable Samprapti Ghataka based on the progression of the disease
- ⇒ To know about Purvarupa of Vatavyadhi
- ⇒ To know about Samanya Lakshana of Vatavyadhi

Introduction

Vatavyadhi is one of the most commonly observed spectrum of diseases in *Ayurveda* clinical practice. It may involve any part of the body. This occurs because of two major pathological mechanisms either through *Margavarana* (obstruction) or through *Dhatu Kshaya* (depletion of body tissue). When we speak about the large intestine and its relation with gas formation, we can get detailed description about amount and content of gas formed in the large intestine. As per Guyton's textbook of physiology, the amount of gases entering or forming in the large intestine each day averages about 7 to 10 liters, whereas the average amount of gas expelled through anus is usually only about 0.6 liters. The remainder of gas is normally absorbed into the blood through intestinal mucosa and expelled through the lungs. Most of the gases are derived from bacterial action in the large intestine such as carbon dioxide, methane and hydrogen. The other sources of gases formation in alimentary canal are swallowed air and gases diffuse from blood into gastrointestinal tract. Thus, *Pakvashaya* (large intestine) is considered to be main source of normal as well as abnormal amounts of *Vata*.

Terminology of Vatavyadhi

While discussing about the description of *Vatavyadhi*, three definitions are seen in literatures.

वात एव व्याधिर्वातव्याधिः,
वातेन जनितो व्याधिर्वातव्याधिः

Madhu, Ma.Ni. – 22/1-4

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वातजनितोऽसाधारणव्याधिर्वातव्याधिरिति Madhu, Ma.Ni. – 22/1-4

These are the different definitions available in *Madhukosha* commentary of *Madhava Nidana*. First definition says *Vata* itself is *Vatavyadhi*. This definition invariably ruled out as far as the definition is concerned, as the person who is perfectly healthy, he will have *Vata Dosha* and you cannot say this normally functioning *Vata* as *Vatavyadhi*.

The second definition says any disease manifested due to the vitiation of *Vata* is considered as *Vatavyadhi*. There are two types of *Vikara* – *Samanyaja* and *Nanatmaja Vikara*. As far as the second definition of *Vatavyadhi* is concerned, vitiated *Vata* can also be observed in *Samanyaja Vikara* in different stage of progression of *Samanyaja Vikara*. Hence, this definition also not describing the exact nature of *Vatavyadhi*.

The third definition of *Vatavyadhi* can be considered as perfect definition of *Vatavyadhi*. Atypical manifestation of the disease due to the vitiation of *Vata* is considered as *Vatavyadhi*.

Nidana of Vatavyadhi

रूक्षशीताल्पलघ्वन्नव्यवायातिप्रजागरैः।

विषमादुपचाराच्च दोषासृक्स्त्रवणादति॥ 15 ॥

लङ्घनप्लवनात्यध्वव्यायामातिविचेष्टितैः।

धातूनां संक्षयाच्चिन्ताशोकरो गाति कर्षणात्॥ 16 ॥

दुःखशय्यासनात् क्रोधादिवास्वप्नाद्भयादपि।

वेगसंधारणादामादभिघातादभोजनात्॥ 17 ॥

मर्माघाताद्गजोष्ट्राश्वशीघ्रयानापतंसनात्।

Ca.Ci. – 28/15-18

We know from our previous sessions that *Vata Dosha* is having *Ruksha* (dry), *Laghu* (light to digest), *Shita* (cold in touch and potency), *Khara* (rough), *Sukshma* (subtle) and *Chala* (unstable) qualities. Whenever, an individual is exposed to the aetiological factors leading to the increase of above said one or more qualities, will lead to the increase of *Vata Dosha* in the body. When we analyse the aetiological factors mentioned in the literatures, we have to look into the effects produced by the aetiological factors and infer the probable quality of *Dosha* increased in the body. This should be considered even for *Pitta* and *Kapha Dosha* also. The other way of interpretation of aetiological factors is to understand the imbalance of *Panchamahabhuta* taking place in the body and thereby predict the vitiation of *Dosha* in the body. In the context of *Vatavyadhi*, the main *Dosha* vitiated will be *Vata Dosha*. Thus, exposure to aetiological factors leading to the increase of *Akasha* and *Vayu Mahabhuta* may be responsible for the manifestation of *Vatavyadhi*.

- ❖ Excess consumption of *Ruksha*¹ (dry) substances or exposure to dry environment.
- ❖ Excess consumption of *Shita* (cold) substances or exposure to cold environment².

- ❖ Excess consumption of *Alpa Bhojana* (little amount of food intake)³.
- ❖ Excess indulgence of sexual intercourse⁴.
- ❖ Awakening at night time frequently⁵.
- ❖ Improper management of the diseases⁶.
- ❖ Excess *Shodhana* (purificatory therapy) or *Panchakarma therapy*⁷.
- ❖ Excess *Raktamokshana* (blood letting therapy)⁸.
- ❖ Excess *Langhana* (measures which leads to lightness of the body).
- ❖ Excess swimming.
- ❖ Excess walking.
- ❖ Excess exercise.
- ❖ Excess physical straining activities.
- ❖ Excess depletion of body tissues⁹.
- ❖ Excess thinking¹⁰.
- ❖ Excess grief.
- ❖ Emaciation of body due to the presence of other diseases.

- 1 When one speaks of consumption of *Ruksha* substances such as bitten rice etc may lead to the excess amount of secretion of juices from the alimentary canal. This may lead to the shrinkage of intravascular compartment to compensate the increased secretion happening in the alimentary canal. If the person is further consuming *Ruksha* substances, it may lead to the transfer of fluid even from interstitial and intracellular compartment. Thus, there may be a shrinkage of intravascular, interstitial and intracellular compartments sequentially. When the person is exposed to *Ruksha* environment, that may be responsible for tanning of the skin, as there is absence of humidity. This is responsible for the shrinkage of intracellular and interstitial compartments.
- 2 Exposure to cold substances and environment can have different effects when exposed to different parts of the body. For example, when a person is exposed cold air, that will have vasoconstriction effect or contraction of airway muscles. When a person is exposed to cold food substances, contraction of alimentary muscles and reduced secretion of gastrointestinal juices can occur. When the person is exposed to cold environment, he may have both peripheral vasoconstriction and contraction of skeletal muscles all over the body. Thus, all these will have impact on either abnormal structure and function of the cell leading to the contraction of the cell and cell organelles.
- 3 When an individual is taking very little amount of food or doing fasting, that may lead to the appearance of hunger pangs or hunger contractions. This occurs when the stomach becomes empty for several hours. These are rhythmical peristaltic contractions in the body of the stomach. Hunger contractions are most intense in the young, healthy people who have high degrees of gastrointestinal tonus; they are also increased by hypoglycemia. These contractions do not begin until 12 to 24 hours after the last food; in starvation, they reach to the peak in 3 to 4 days and gradually weaken in the successive days. This mechanism will lead to gradual depletion of carbohydrate, fat and proteins sequentially. Thus, the person may have emaciation of the body.
- 4 Frequent sexual intercourse will lead to the increase of basal metabolic rate, thus, the person may have gradual depletion of nutrients of the body.
- 5 Ayurveda literatures say if an individual avoids sleep, that will lead to the increase of *Ruksha* (dry) quality in the body. Frequent night outs may lead to the excess increase of *Ruksha* quality in the body, thus increases *Vata Dosha* in the body.
- 6 If a person is receiving any improper treatment when an individual is suffering from any of the diseases, that may lead to the inflammatory responses in the body. This will lead to the multiple responses in the body ranging from increased WBC production, hampered RBC formation, rapid nutrients depletion etc. All above mechanisms will lead to cellular injury either reversible or irreversible.
- 7 When a suffering individual is given excess amount of *Shodhana* or purification therapy, that will lead to excess loss of fluid from the alimentary canal. This will lead to the shift of the fluid from intravascular compartment into alimentary canal. The loss of fluid in the intravascular compartment is later replaced by shift of fluid from interstitial and intracellular compartments respectively. Thus, we can expect *Vata Dosha* vitiation in the frequent administration of *Shodhana* therapy.
- 8 When an individual is administered *Raktamokshana* therapy, that will lead to rapid depletion of fluid in the intravascular compartment, which leads to the shift of the fluid from interstitial and intracellular compartments respectively. In case of *Shodhana* therapy, fluid loss starts from alimentary canal whereas in case of *Raktamokshana*, fluid loss starts from intravascular compartment.
- 9 All above activities are responsible for the rapid depletion of carbohydrates, fats and proteins sequentially. Thus, the person will have progressive emaciation of the body and body parts secondary to the loss of the nutrients.
- 10 A thought results from a pattern of stimulation of many parts of the nervous system at the same time, probably involving cerebral cortex, thalamus, limbic system, upper reticular formation of brain stem. This requires glucose and other electrolytes. Frequent thinking requires glucose and other electrolytes, leading to rapid nutrient loss from the body.

- Uncomfortable sitting posture.
- Uncomfortable sleeping posture¹¹.
- Anger¹²
- Sleeping during day time¹³.
- Fear¹⁴
- Injury to *Marma* (vital points of the body)¹⁵.
- Excess traveling in elephant, camel, horse¹⁶.
- Falling from the height¹⁷.

Samprapti of Vatavyadhi

देहे स्रोतांसि रिक्तानि पूरयित्वाऽनिलो बली॥ 1 8॥
करोति विविधान् व्याधीन् सर्वाङ्गैकाङ्गसंश्रितान्।

Ca.Ci. – 28/18,19

- The vitiated *Vata Dosha* will fill the empty spaces of *Srotas*.
- There will be manifestation of *Vatavyadhi* either localised or generalised area of the body.

Purvarupa of Vatavyadhi

अव्यक्तं लक्षणं तेषां पूर्वरूपमिति स्मृतम्॥

Ca.Ci. – 28/19

- Poorly manifested symptom is considered to be *Purvarupa* of *Vatavyadhi*.

Samanya Lakshana of Vatavyadhi

सङ्कोचः पर्वणां स्तम्भो भेदोऽस्नां पर्वणामपि॥ 2 0॥
लोमहर्षः प्रलापश्च पाणिपृष्ठशिरोग्रहः।
खाड्यपाङ्गुल्यकुञ्चत्वं शोषोऽङ्गानामनिद्रता॥ 2 1॥
गर्भशुक्ररजोनाशः स्पन्दनं गात्रसुता।
शिरोनासाक्षिजत्रूणां ग्रीवायाश्चापि हुण्डनम्॥ 2 2॥
भेदस्तदार्तिक्षेपो मोहश्चायास एव च।
एवंविधानि रूपाणि करोति कुपितोऽनिलः॥ 2 3॥
हेतुस्थानविशेषाच्च भवेद्रोगविशेषकृत्।

Ca.Ci. – 28/20-24

- Development of contracture
- Stiffness of the joints
- Tearing type of pain in the bones¹⁸
- Tearing type of pain in the joints
- Horripulation¹⁹
- Irrelevant and incomprehensible speech²⁰
- Less movement of hands or stiff hands
- Less movement of back or stiff back
- Less movement of head or stiffness of the head²¹
- Loss of movement of one lower limb²²
- Loss of movement of both lower limbs²³
- Less height
- Dryness of the body parts²⁴

G
K

- Uncomfortable sitting and sleeping posture will lead to increased and persistent contraction of muscles which leads to the muscular spasm.
- When a person is exposed to frequent anger, it stimulates the sympathetic nervous system. The overstimulation may be responsible for tachycardia, hypertension, reduced secretion in the alimentary canal and oversecretion of adrenal medulla. All these mechanisms are leading to the increase of Ushna and Chala Guna in the body.
- As per Ayurveda literatures, sleeping during day time is responsible for the increase of Kapha Dosha. Frequent indulgence in sleep during day time is responsible for the increase of Ama, as it is one specific factor which is considered to be Santarpanaja (over nourishment) Nidana.
- When a person is exposed to fear, it may indicate the activation of sympathetic nervous system. This activation leads to tachycardia, reduced secretion in the alimentary canal, palpitation etc. All above said features indicate the Chala quality getting increased in the body.
- Injury to Kalantara Pranahara Marma (injury to vital points leading to life threatening situation in the long run) or Rujakara Marma (injury to vital points responsible for the pain at the site of the injury) indirectly implies the dominance of Vata in the body.
- Excess travelling in different modes may lead to more burning of energy which will generate energy.
- Nature and area of injury determines the vitiation of Vata Dosha when a person falls from height. If there is head injury, the person may show signs of head injury such as unconsciousness or speech deformities or cranial nerve dysfunction which may indicate the vitiation of Vata Dosha in the body. If the person is having trauma to the back or limbs, there is a possibility of fracture of the bones which may require prolonged immobilisation which may lead to disuse atrophy. As per Ayurveda literature, when a person is presented with pain, it invariably indicates the vitiation of Vata Dosha in the body.
- Presence of any type of pain in any part of the body is indicative of vitiation of Vata Dosha in the affected part.
- This can be attributable to piloerection i.e. hairs standing on the end. Sympathetic nervous stimulation causes erector pili to contract and leading to the position of hairs of the body to become upright stance. This is typically seen in lower animals. As per the current understanding, it is an involuntary activity and this is usually observed when a person is exposed to cold environment. It is one of the mechanism which helps in the maintenance of body temperature. That means exposure of the individual to Shita (cold) environment leads to the increase of Chala quality, and at a time, we can observe the increase of Shita and Chala qualities in the body.
- When an individual is having abnormal speech production, it may suggest the involvement of Udanavata and Pranavata during the pathogenesis. Production of speech is a specific function of Vak Indriya and it is under the influence of Udanavata. Pranavata is the Vata which controls the mind which is essential for the production of speech. Irrelevant and incomprehensible speech may indicate abnormal Udanavata and Pranavata.
- When an individual is having the increase of Akasha Mahabhuta, the person may have the poor or less movement of the body and body parts.
- This clinical feature is indicative of clinical conditions leading to monoplegia or monoparesis of lower limb.
- This clinical feature is indicative of clinical conditions leading to paraplegia or paraparesis.
- When a person is exposed to cold and dry weather in winter, we can observe the dryness of skin of different parts of the body. This is attrib-

- ① Loss of sleep²⁵
- ① Destruction of Garbha²⁶ (pregnancy)
- ① Loss of Shukra (semen)
- ① Loss of menstruation²⁷
- ① Abnormal pulsations²⁸ in the body
- ① Tingling sensation²⁹ in the body parts

- ① Shiro Hundana³⁰ – cracks or dandruff observed in the head or scalp region
- ① Nasa Hundana³¹ – loss of smell perception
- ① Akshi Hundana³² – paralysis observed around the eyes
- ① Jatru Hundana³³ – disturbance of neck region
- ① Griva Hundana³⁴ – stiffness of the neck region

Key summary of the chapter

वातजनितोऽसाधारणव्याधिर्वातव्याधिरिति

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- ① Atypical manifestation of the disease due to the vitiation of Vata is considered as Vatavyadhi.
- ① As far as Nidana of Vatavyadhi are concerned, all Nidana are responsible for Apatarpana effect in the body (lightness of the body) except Divasvapna (sleeping during day time) and presence of Ama in the body (as Ama is having similar effects of the Kapha Dosha in the body).
- ① As far as Purvarupa of Vatavyadhi is concerned, it is mentioned that Avyakta (poorly manifestation of the symptoms) are the Purvarupa in case of Vatavyadhi.
- ① Sankocha (development of contractures), Parvanam Stambha (stiffness of the joints), Asthibheda (tearing type of pain in the bones), Parvabheda (tearing type of pain in the joints) etc are mentioned as Samanya Lakshana of Vatavyadhi.

Self-Assessment: Questions for Reviews

Long essays

- ① Explain the Nidana, Samprapti, Purvarupa and Rupa of the Vatavyadhi

- b. Divaswapna;
- c. Plavana;
- d. Shoka

Answer: (b)

Short essays

- ① Explain Nidana of Vatavyadhi
- ① Explain the Samanya Rupa of Vatavyadhi

2. Purvarupa of Vatavyadhi is

- a. Ekangavata;
- b. Ardita;
- c. Kampa;
- d. Avyakta Lakshana

Answer: (d)

MCQs

- 1. Which of the following is having Santarpana effect among Nidana of Vatavyadhi?

- a. Ruksha Bhojana;

① utable to the increase of Ruksha quality in the body.

25 When a person is exposed to loss of sleep, as per Ayurveda literature, it may be responsible for the increase of Ruksha quality in the body, which is an indication of Vata Dosha vitiation in the body.

26 This may indicate the affliction of Apanavata in the seat of Apanavata.

27 This can be attributable to the affliction of Apanavata in the body. This may be responsible for the reverse movement of Vata. As we observe the reverse movement, it may indicate the obstruction of the passage of Apanavata either in the male or female reproductive system.

28 This could be either increased pulsations or reduced pulsations or irregular pulsations. This can be observed in either one or more parts of the body. this can be attributable to the increase or decrease of Chala quality in the body. The increase in Chala quality may indicate the increase of Akasha Mahabhuta in the body.

29 increase of Vayu Mahabhuta in the body and reduced Chala quality may indicate the dysfunction of Vyanavata as body parts increase of Vayu Mahabhuta in the body and reduced Chala quality may indicate the dysfunction of Vyanavata as body parts

30 Tingling sensation is observed in sensory nervous system dysfunction. It can be attributable to the dysfunction of Vyanavata as body parts

31 affections can be observed. The term Hundana is used contextually. Here, the person will have cracks in the head region or dandruff observed in the head region. This refers to poor blood supply in the head region or poor peripheral vaso constriction. Due to poor blood supply, the person will have dryness of the scalp region and it indicates the increase of Ruksha quality in the head region.

32 The term Nasa Hundana refers to poor smell perception. Smell perception can be abnormal in case of poor nasal secretion or poor olfactory function or nasal obstruction. In this context, it can be taken as poor olfactory function. This is attributable to poor functioning of Pranavata.

33 The term Akshi Hundana refers to the paralysis observed in the ocular region. This can be observed in both upper and lower motor facial function or nasal obstruction. In this context, it can be taken as poor olfactory function. This is attributable to poor functioning of Vyanavata.

34 The term Jatru Hundana refers to the disturbance of the neck region. This can be attributable to either disturbance of sternocleidomastoid muscle or trapezius muscle which is attached to the neck region. This could be attributable to the poor functioning of Vyanavata.

Stiffness of the neck region can be observed in either disturbance of sternocleidomastoid muscle or trapezius muscle. This is seen in case of the increase of Laghu and Ruksha qualities in the neck region which indicates the increase of Vata Dosha in the neck region.

3. Avyakta Lakshana is considered asof Vatavyadhi.

- a. Nidana; b. Purvarupa;
- c. Rupa; d. Upadrava

Answer: (b)

4. The term Nasahundana as per Chakrapani refers to

- a. Deviated Nasal septum;
- b. Absence of smell perception;
- c. Running nose;
- d. Absence of nose

Answer: (b)

5. The term Pangu refers to

- a. Loss of functioning of one lower limb;
- b. Loss of functioning of both lower limbs;
- c. Loss of functioning of both lower limbs and one upper limb;
- d. Loss of functioning of all four limbs

Answer: (b)

Chapter resources

- ⊗ Charaka Samhita Chikitsa Sthana – 28th chapter: Vatavyadhi Chikitsa Adhyaya
- ⊗ Sushruta Samhita Nidana Sthana – 1st chapter: Vatavyadhi Nidana Adhyaya

- ⊗ Madhava Nidana: 22nd chapter: Vatavyadhi Nidana Adhyaya
- ⊗ Ashtanga Hridaya Nidana Adhyaya: 15th chapter: Vatavyadhi Nidana Adhyaya
- ⊗ Ashtanga Sangraha Nidana Adhyaya: 15th chapter: Vatavyadhi Nidana Adhyaya
- ⊗ Golwalla's medicine for students by Aspi F Golwalla and Sharukh A Golwalla, edited by Milind Y Nadkar, 25th edition, Jaypee Brothers Medical Publishers (P) Ltd, New Delhi, 2017
- ⊗ The Merck Manual of Diagnosis and Therapy by Robert S Porter and Justin L Kaplan, 19th edition, Merck Sharp & Dohme Corp, New Jersey, 2011
- ⊗ Chamberlain's symptoms and signs in clinical medicine by Colin Ogilvie and Christopher C Evans, 12th edition, Butterworth-Heinemann Publishers, 1997
- ⊗ Best & Taylor's physiological basis of medical practice by O P Tandon and Y Tripathi, 13th edition, Wolters Kluwer Health (India) Pvt. Ltd, Gurgaon, 2012
- ⊗ Textbook of Medical physiology by Arthur C Guyton and John E Hall, 11th edition, Saunders Elsevier publications, Philadelphia, 2006
